

COLUMBIA BUSINESS SCHOOL

INSIDER TIPS



ABOUT COLUMBIA

Located in New York City, Columbia Business School (CBS) highlights that it is at the very “center of business,” helping bright students think like entrepreneurs and helping them develop as leaders.

The symbiotic relationship between CBS and the business world is a major program benefit, and each year many business leaders visit the campus to speak to business school students and to teach classes. Indeed, CBS notes on its website, “more business leaders visit our campus than any other top business school.” Because of its NYC location, the school also attracts more than 100 real-world practitioners as faculty (adjunct) in the business school.

While fortifying Columbia’s strength in finance, CBS has made experiential learning, entrepreneurial thinking, and global perspectives the cornerstones of the program.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

Known for its strengths in a wide variety of areas, including accounting, finance, general management, entrepreneurship, economics, media, marketing, healthcare/pharma, consumer goods and real estate.

KEY STATS

MBA RANKINGS*	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	13	-	5	6	11	-	-	9
Financial Times	5	5	5	6	6	7	7	6
Forbes	-	7	-	4	-	6	-	7
The Economist	5	7	10	12	11	-	-	12
US News	8	8	8	8	10	9	9	6

CLASS OF 2021

Number of Applicants	5876
MBA Class Size	754
Yield	68%
Total Tuition	\$154,752

ADMISSIONS

Avg Age	28
Avg GMAT	727
Avg GPA	3.6
Int'l Students	47%

POST-MBA CAREERS

Financial Services	34%
Consulting	33%
Technology	14%
Starting a Business	5%

TOP RECRUITERS INCLUDE:

McKinsey, Goldman Sachs, BCG, Bain, PwC, Strategy&, Deloitte

AVERAGE BASE SALARY: US\$150,000

EMPLOYED IN 3 MONTHS: 94%

*Rankings are relative to other U.S. business schools. [Read more](#) about the Fortuna ranking methodology.



TOP TIPS FOR ACING YOUR COLUMBIA APPLICATION

BY KAREN HAMOU

Karen is a Columbia Business School MBA alumna and former Deloitte Consulting recruiting lead. After graduating from Columbia, Karen joined Deloitte Consulting's Strategy and Operations practice where she worked on a range of retail projects. While at the firm, she served as Deloitte's on-campus recruiting representative at CBS, guiding over 130 CBS students through their consulting recruiting process. She also participated in a firm initiative advising junior consultants as they applied to MBA programs.



**The city is fast-paced, cosmopolitan
and decisive, so how do you fit into
Columbia's New York culture?**

1

ADVANTAGES OF APPLYING EARLY

Columbia Business School operates on a rolling admissions process – both for early and regular decisions – and applications are reviewed in the order that they are received. There are clear advantages for applying early to Columbia, as the pool will be smaller and your application will likely gain greater visibility. For those who have scored on the lower end of the school's GMAT range, you may specifically want to consider Early Decision; Admissions can be more flexible at this initial stage, knowing that they can make up for this shortfall in the regular pool. Bear in mind that while the rest of the top b-schools wait until January to receive the second round of applications, Columbia is reviewing files from early October onwards, so don't wait until the New Year.

WORK EXPERIENCE

2

On average, Columbia Business School students come into the program with five years professional experience and most have at least three years. If you have less than three years of work, it will be that much harder to get admitted. You will have to demonstrate to Admissions that your professional experience is either unusual or differentiating; or that you have had some significant achievements, despite your shorter professional experience.

3

INTERVIEWING

Candidates typically get to choose whom they want to be interviewed by from a list of alumni who are close by. It's advisable to choose someone with similar career interests, if possible. The interviewer will only be able to see your resume so will not have your full application to review. There will be the standard questions related to "why b-school, career goals, team work experience, etc." But you may likely be asked to focus on why you would choose Columbia over other top programs, as Columbia sometimes loses out to these competitors.

LOCATION, LOCATION, LOCATION

4

Columbia knows that one of its unique advantages is being (as they put it) "at the very center of business." The Admissions Committee wants to admit applicants who will utilize the full resources not only of the school, but also of the city, during their MBA experience.

From Wall Street to media, consulting to real estate, the school has faculty expertise and Centers of Excellence that reflect the diversity of the Big Apple. The Columbia Startup Lab launched in June '14 in NYC's Silicon Alley, helping CBS students and alumni develop their new ideas and pursue their ventures after graduation. The city is fast-paced, cosmopolitan and decisive, so how do you fit into Columbia's New York culture?

5

POSITIONING FOR THE J-TERM

Columbia is alone among the top US business schools in offering a January intake. So if you are determined to secure a place without waiting until the following September this could be a great option for you. But there are a couple of aspects of the program for you to be aware of that could influence your admissions success.

First, the 'J-Term' at Columbia replaces the summer internship with a semester of study. You pretty much have the campus to yourselves, before joining up with the Columbia students who are returning to complete their second year. The program is not really intended for career switchers who needed a summer internship to open up new opportunities. The J-Term class tends to be dominated by consultants who will be heading back to McKinsey, Bain or BCG, people from family businesses, and entrepreneurs. So when Columbia asks you why you are pursuing an MBA at this time, you'd better get your career story straight. If it's apparent that you are looking to make a major shift that requires an internship, the admissions office may well feel you are not best suited to this program format.

The J-Term is also very international, with US citizens making up less than half the class. So if you have professional or academic experience outside your home country it will be worth pointing to a global mindset that will ensure you thrive in this particular New York melting pot.

ESSAY ANALYSIS

Columbia is looking to see that you know what you want to do, have a general understanding of that role, and that you understand the paths that would be available to you coming out of Columbia.



SHORT ANSWER. "What is your immediate post-MBA professional goal?" (50 characters)

The Admissions team wants you to be direct, succinct and demonstrate direction (ambition is good but be realistic). There is no right answer here, but whatever you choose should be coherent and credible based on your past experience combined with the Columbia MBA. Columbia is looking to see that you know what you want to do, have a general understanding of that role, and that you understand the paths that would be available to you coming out of Columbia.

ESSAY 1. "Through your resume and recommendations, we have a clear sense of your professional path to date. What are your career goals over the next 3-5 years and what, in your imagination, would be your long-term dream job?" (500 words)

A common mistake here is to focus on where you have been rather than where you are going. It often helps to start with a brief hook to show what inspires you to take the path that you will then lay out. Then, offer a (very brief) paragraph explaining what you have done on that career path to date. Short-term goals can be more specific than long-term goals. You certainly need to have a general idea of what you would like to do in the long term, but given that it would be quite a few years out, the admissions committee is not expecting the same level of detail there as they are for the immediate post-MBA goals. Again, Columbia is looking to see that you have a clear understanding of where its MBA can take you (and then essay 2 will show how the MBA will help you get there).

ESSAY 2. "Why do you feel Columbia Business School is a good fit for you" (250 words)

This feels very similar to previous years' prompt ('why do you want to be at the very center of business?') except the wording is much more straightforward. This essay question prompts you to explain why CBS is uniquely positioned to help you achieve your goals. It is a great opportunity to demonstrate that you have done your homework and are passionate about attending Columbia. You should showcase your deep knowledge of the school and the engagement that you've had with members of the Columbia community. Even though it isn't directly in the essay prompt this year as it was previously, you should still explain not only why Columbia's campus life is right for you, but also why want to pursue the MBA in New York City, as NYC is such an integral part of the Columbia experience.

ESSAY 3. "Tell us about your favorite book, movie or song and why it resonates with you." (250 words)

This essay is where you can really display who you are under the surface, beyond the ambitious achiever with a sparkling record of successes. While essay 1 shows the professional path you want to take in life, essay 3 can add the additional depth of the type of person, and business leader, you want to be. So whether your artistic choice is an undisputed classic, political satire or a Steampunk thriller, do not get stuck trying to pick the perfect, most impressive one. What is much more important here is WHY you have selected this story, what you learned from it, how it inspires you, and how it may have impacted your professional or personal decisions.

DEADLINES & DATES*

	APPLICATION DEADLINE
January 2021 Intake	2 October 2020
August 2021 - Early Decision	2 October 2020
August 2021 - Merit Fellowship	6 January 2021
August 2021 - Final Deadline	9 April 2021

***COVID-19**

For the latest updates about how COVID-19 is impacting admissions and programming at Columbia and all top MBA programs, please visit our [blog](#).



**The best time to
apply is when you're
ready.**

Caroline Diarte Edwards,
Co-Founder & Director of Fortuna Admissions

LET'S GET YOU IN.

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Yale SOM, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: FortunaAdmissions.com

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